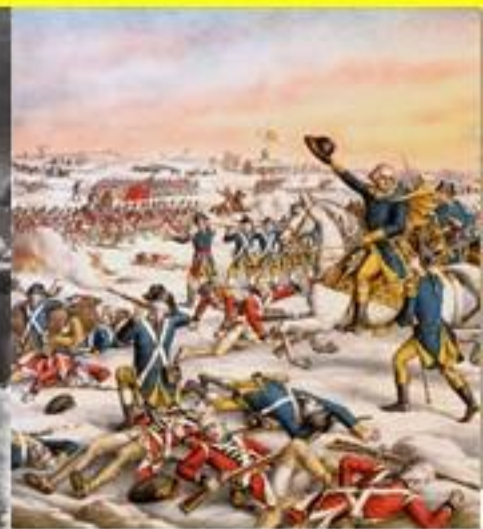


WORLD HISTORY



MODULE - 24

UNIFICATION OF GERMANY - 1

UNIFICATION OF GERMANY

1 HOLY ROMAN EMPIRE

- 1 Since 9th century, the German states were bound together in a loose political entity known as the holy roman empire.
- 2 There were hundreds of small states, duchies etc., which were semi-autonomous under the holy roman empire.
- 3 During Napoleonic wars French armies occupied Germany, moved through, or were allied with the German states.
- 4 In 1806 the holy roman empire was dissolved. In the congress of Vienna (1814-15) a major question was what to do with central Europe in general and Germany in particular.



UNIFICATION OF GERMANY

2 CONFEDERATION OF GERMAN STATES

- 1 Germans had hoped that the settlement will result in unified Germany, but instead, to the dismay and disgust of the people, they got a confederation of 39 German states.
- 2 This arrangement created many more problems rather than solutions.
- 3 The parochialism and particularism were deep rooted in German states.
- 4 Unlike in case of Italy where Sardinia-piedmont was the dominant state, in case of German unification there were two strong powers i.e., Austria and Prussia, both were willing to unify Germany under their respective aegis.





Kingdom of Denmark

D of Schleswig

D of Holstein

Kingdom of the Netherlands

Kingdom of Hanover

Kingdom of Prussia
Berlin

EMPIRE OF RUSSIA

Kingdom of Prussia

Kingdom of Saxony

Kingdom of Belgium

D of Luxembourg

EMPIRE OF THE FRENCH

ALSCE-LORRAINE

Kingdom of Bavaria

EMPIRE OF AUSTRIA

Baden

Switzerland

Kingdom of Italy

EARLY ATTEMPTS FOR UNIFICATION

1 IMPACT OF 1848 REVOLUTION

1 In the year 1848 the revolution started in France which envisioned liberalism, nationalism and democracy and was against the principles of balance of power and legitimacy as advocated by the congress of Vienna.

2 The revolution had deep impact on whole Europe and Germany was no exception.



2 DEMAND FOR LIBERAL CONSTITUTION

- 1 In Germany the champions of revolution demanded that each state should be given a liberal constitution.
- 2 In the same year the states had a meeting in which a liberal program was adopted.
- 3 The other demands of the agitations were that there should be freedom of press, perfect religious toleration and also trial by jury.



2 DEMAND FOR LIBERAL CONSTITUTION

- 4 A demand was also made for consisting assemblies consisting of elected representatives of the people, in every state. Thus for the time being the liberalism triumphed all over Germany.
- 5 Under the utmost pressure of the liberal revolutionaries the rule of Prussia; William IV also agreed to give liberal constitution after some clashes between his army and people.
- 6 He also promised to assure the leadership of the national movement for the unified Germany.



PARLIAMENT OF FRANKFURT

- 1** The acceptance of Prussian king for a liberal constitution and **national unity** stirred up immense fervour among the German liberals.
- 2** They summoned a national parliament which met at Frankfurt in 1848.
- 3** It was at this meeting that it was decided that Germany should have a **bicameral legislature** and a **federal government**.
- 4** It was also agreed that the people of Germany should be given certain **fundamental rights**, which included freedom of press, trial by jury, abolition of special privileges and religious and civil equality.



PARLIAMENT OF FRANKFURT

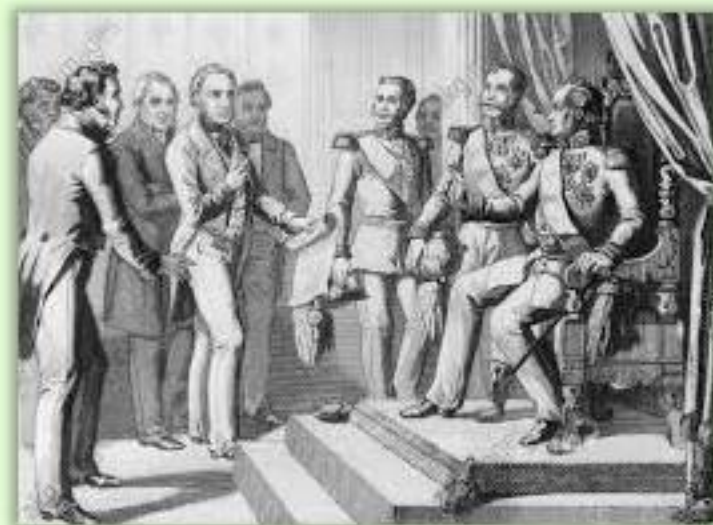
- 5 In the assembly there was school of thought commonly known 'Little Germans' which believed that Austria should be excluded.
- 6 Whereas the others called 'Great Germans' were of the view that Austria should be included. After great deliberations it was decided that Austria should be kept out.
- 7 The assembly decided that there should be a hereditary king and a German confederation.

- 8 It also decided that the throne should be offered to Fredrick Williams IV but did not accept the offer.



WHY FREDRICK WILLIAM IV REJECTED THRONE?

- 1** He was conservative by nature, earlier only under the pressure of revolution he agreed to give a liberal constitution to Prussia and to be front runner for the German unity.
- 2** He did not agree with many of the demands of Frankfurt parliament.
- 3** He did not wish to remain as a serf in the hands of revolutionaries, particularly when he believed in the theory of divine rights of kings. He looked upon the crown given by revolutionaries as the "crown of shame"
- 4** He was not prepared to fight with Austria which had been excluded from the assembly. He knew that in any such war he will be defeated.



5 **Set back:** The refusal of king William IV of Prussia to be leader of parliament proved to be a huge setback for the liberalism and revolutionaries.

- ✓ It was also clear to the nationalists that unification of Germany through liberal principles was impossible in those circumstances.
- ✓ All efforts made to frame a new constitution failed and the people were now convinced that not constitutional but some other methods will have to be used if Germany was to be unified.
- ✓ Austria regained her influence as the German unity passed into oblivion.

6 The revolution of 1848 although was unable to achieve its final goal, yet it **cannot be termed** as a total **failure**.

7 The liberal and democratic tendencies got a huge impetus in Germany as a result of this and most importantly the king of Prussia William IV had to accept constitutional monarchy in his state.



ZOLLVEREIN

- 1** Although in the congress of Vienna the political unification of Germany was checked by the reactionary forces, the market forces which were in the pursuit of economic unification based on free trade cannot be curtailed.
- 2** Initially, in various states there were many custom areas which were a great stumbling block in flourishing of trade.
- 3** Prussia had thus remained much behind England in trade and commerce. The trade and commerce in the states were also marred by smuggling.
- 4** In 1818 on the initiative of Prussia, a customs union or zollverein was established, consisting of the neighbouring states based on the free trade.



ZOLLVEREIN

5 In zollverein the member states removed the trade barriers and it was also provided that there will be uniform tariff on all frontiers and net proceeds will be divided on the basis of the population of the states.

6 Importance of zollverein was not fully realized initially by Austria. By 1850 most of the states joined zollverein except Austria.

7 Even Austria who was not very keen to join it in the beginning became a keen to become its members.



ZOLLVEREIN

8 But Prussia had decided that Austria should keep away from it. In 1853 Austria was, however, in a position to get some concession from Zollverein.

9 According to various historians Zollverein provided the viable material base for the unification of Germany. It was for the first time that Germany became fiscal and commercial unit.

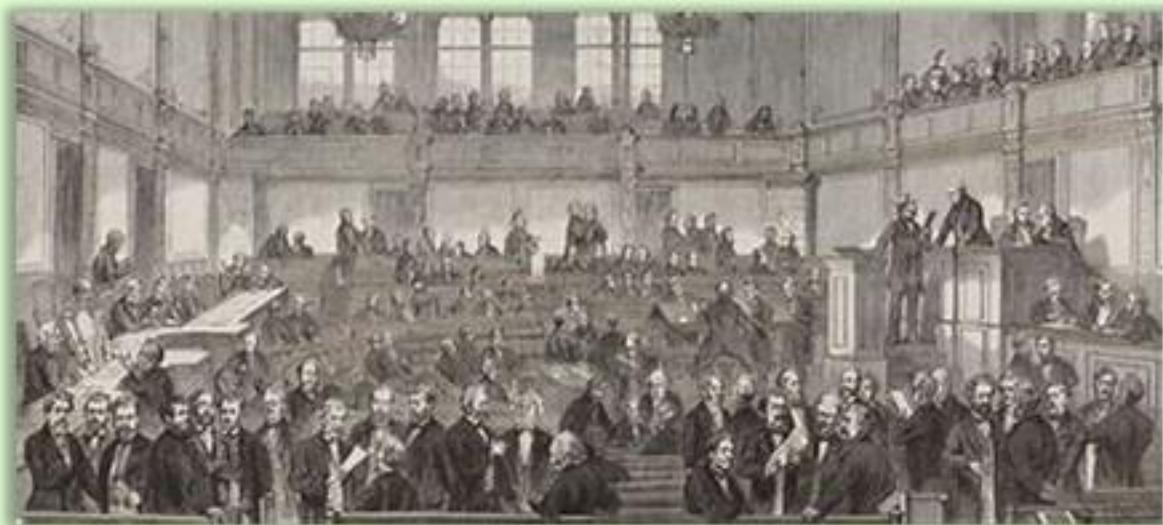
10 It helped in uniting Germany in the bonds of mutual economic interests.



ZOLLVEREIN

ZOLLVEREIN PROVED TO BE BENEFICIAL FOR PRUSSIA IN FOLLOWING WAYS

- 1** The free trade and commerce strengthened the economy of Prussia and other states.
- 2** Prussia now emerged as a leader of German states. Austria which did not join zollverein was practically out of leadership race.
- 3** Prussia gained the support of rich and influential capitalist class and bankers who were of the view that their counterparts in England could do better in trade and commerce because of the political and economic unification.
- 4** Thus they became ardent supporters of unification.



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